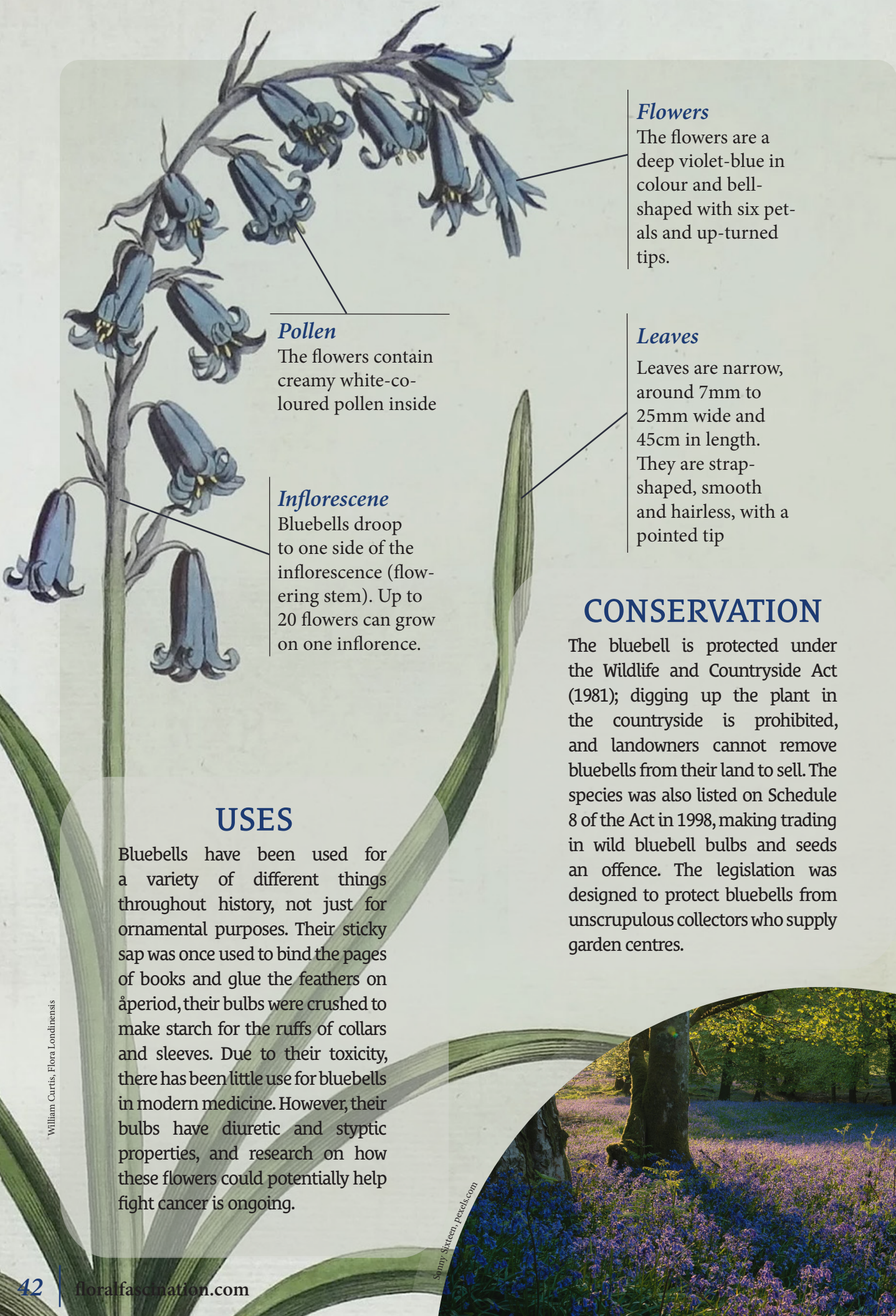




Flowers

The flowers are a deep violet-blue in colour and bell-shaped with six petals and up-turned tips.

Pollen

The flowers contain creamy white-coloured pollen inside

Inflorescence

Bluebells droop to one side of the inflorescence (flowering stem). Up to 20 flowers can grow on one inflorescence.

Leaves

Leaves are narrow, around 7mm to 25mm wide and 45cm in length. They are strap-shaped, smooth and hairless, with a pointed tip

CONSERVATION

The bluebell is protected under the Wildlife and Countryside Act (1981); digging up the plant in the countryside is prohibited, and landowners cannot remove bluebells from their land to sell. The species was also listed on Schedule 8 of the Act in 1998, making trading in wild bluebell bulbs and seeds an offence. The legislation was designed to protect bluebells from unscrupulous collectors who supply garden centres.

USES

Bluebells have been used for a variety of different things throughout history, not just for ornamental purposes. Their sticky sap was once used to bind the pages of books and glue the feathers on a period, their bulbs were crushed to make starch for the ruffs of collars and sleeves. Due to their toxicity, there has been little use for bluebells in modern medicine. However, their bulbs have diuretic and styptic properties, and research on how these flowers could potentially help fight cancer is ongoing.

William Curtis, Flora Londinensis

Sunny Sixteen, pixels.com

BLUEBELL

Hyacinthoides non-scripta



Click and Learn Photography, unsplash.com

Wildlife Value

Many insects reap the benefits of bluebells which flower earlier than many other plants. Woodland butterflies, bees and hoverflies all feed on their nectar. Bees can 'steal' the nectar from bluebells by biting a hole in the bottom of the flower, reaching the nectar without the need to pollinate the flower.

Bluebells spend the majority of their time underground as bulbs, emerging, often in droves, to flower from April onwards.

Where To Find

Bluebells are native to western Europe with the UK being a species stronghold. They're associated with ancient woodland and are often used in combination with other species as a clue that a wood is ancient. They reach their greatest densities in the UK's woods where many thousands of bulbs can exist in one woodland, creating the incredible blue carpets we fondly associate with spring. They also grow along hedgerows and in fields.

Symbolism

There are countless folklore tales surrounding bluebells, many of which involve dark fairy magic. Bluebell woods are believed to be intricately woven with fairy enchantments, used by these mischievous beings to trap humans. It is also said that if you hear a bluebell ring, you will be visited by a bad fairy, and will die not long after. If you are to pick a bluebell, many believe you will be led astray by fairies, lost forevermore. (Article from woodlandtrust.org.uk).



Cicely Mary Barker, Flower Fairies